

CHORD INVERSIONS

The same chord tones reordered — inversions create smooth bass lines, voice leading efficiency, and new emotional shades.

An **inversion** places any chord tone other than the root in the lowest (bass) voice. The chord name doesn't change — only which note is on the bottom. Notated as **Chord/Bass** (e.g., C/E means C chord with E in the bass).

TRIAD INVERSIONS — C MAJOR (C-E-G)

POSITION	BASS NOTE	STABILITY	NOTATION	CHARACTER
Root Position	Root (C)	 Most stable	C	<i>Grounded foundation. Strong arrival point. Use for beginnings, endings, and strong beats.</i>
1st Inversion	3rd (E)	 Lighter	C/E	<i>Smooth, elegant, slightly softer. Excellent for harmonizing scale degree 3 in the melody (creates seamless motion in the bass).</i>
2nd Inversion	5th (G)	 Least stable	C/G	<i>Creates a P4 above the bass — contextually unstable. Used in specific contexts: cadential 6/4 (IV 2nd inv before V) or passing movement.</i>

7TH CHORD INVERSIONS — G7 (G-B-D-F)

POSITION	BASS NOTE	STABILITY	NOTATION	CHARACTER
Root Position	Root (G)	 Most stable	G7	<i>Full, strong dominant. Direct and powerful resolution drive.</i>
1st Inversion	3rd (B)	 Lighter	G7/B	<i>Smooths the bass line when harmonizing scale degree 7. Classic pop use: harmonizes B in the melody moving up to C (e.g., "Man in the Mirror").</i>
2nd Inversion	5th (D)	 Less stable	G7/D	<i>Less common. The D in the bass weakens dominant drive slightly. Used for passing motion or pedal tone contexts.</i>
3rd Inversion	7th (F)	 Most active	G7/F	<i>The F (♭7) in the bass creates a harsh m2 against the expected resolution. Creates maximum forward pull. Used in Bach chorales and dramatic jazz passages.</i>

THREE FUNCTIONAL INVERSIONS YOU'LL ACTUALLY USE

1

I/3RD
C/E

Softens the harmonization of scale degree 3 in the melody. Creates a smooth descending bass line: C → C/E → F. Commonly used in pop ballads for a gentler Tonic chord.

2

V/7TH
G/B

"Man in the Mirror" — MJ bridge
Smooth harmonization of scale degree 7 ascending to 8 (B → C). The B in the bass rises stepwise to C — the most elegant possible bass resolution. Pop and gospel staple.

3

III/5TH
Em/B

"Shape of My Heart" — Sting
Most melancholic harmonization of scale degree 5. Em/B creates a descending bass line feel (G → Em/B → C/E). The B in the bass sustains before resolving. Deeply introspective character.